A Complete Small Group Study Resource

Philemon 1–7

A Cautious Approach

The Epistle to Philemon

Small Group Bible Study Series · Philemon · Study 1 of 3

Source: Dr. C Norman Sellers ThD sellersbibleinstitute.com (used by permission)
Editor: The Gospel Vault

① TEXT	② DEVOTIONAL	③ COMMENTARY	④ SELF-STUDY GUIDE
Foundation	Personal prep	Teacher preparation	Group meeting
Everyone	All group members	Teacher / Leader	Small group

⑤ *Application closes each study and draws from all sections above.*

① BIBLICAL TEXT

NKJV · Philemon 1–7

1 *Paul, a prisoner of Christ Jesus, and Timothy our brother, To Philemon our beloved friend and fellow laborer,*

2 *to the beloved Apphia, Archippus our fellow soldier, and to the church in your house:*

3 *Grace to you and peace from God our Father and the Lord Jesus Christ.*

4 *I thank my God, making mention of you always in my prayers,*

5 *hearing of your love and faith which you have toward the Lord Jesus and toward all the saints,*

6 *that the sharing of your faith may become effective by the acknowledgment of every good thing which is in you in Christ Jesus.*

7 *For we have great joy and consolation in your love, because the hearts of the saints have been refreshed by you, brother.*

Scripture taken from the New King James Version®. Copyright © 1982 by Thomas Nelson. Used by permission. All rights reserved.

② DEVOTIONAL

Personal preparation · All group members

> *“For we have great joy and consolation in your love, because the hearts of the saints have been refreshed by you, brother. — Philemon 7”*

Paul had all the leverage he could want, and he didn’t use the hammer. Before he ever mentions the runaway slave Onesimus, he greets Philemon as “our beloved friend and fellow laborer,” claims him as one of his own, and wishes him grace and peace. There is nothing like expressed appreciation. When someone says, “You are a blessing to me,” it feels good, and it is a proper thing to do.

Then Paul tells Philemon that he prays for him always, because he has heard of his love toward all the saints — all of them, and Onesimus is one of them now. That love grew out of the faith Philemon possessed. If you love the Lord, you love the Lord’s people.

And Paul is glad. Philemon’s love had refreshed the hearts of the saints — the same word Jesus used when He said, “I will give you rest.” Then Paul adds one word: “brother.” Before any hard request, he sets the stage with grace.

Reflect

1. Who in your life needs to hear you say, “You are a blessing to me” this week?
2. Does your love reach “all the saints,” or only the ones who are easy to love?
3. What burden have you taken to the Lord in prayer and then picked back up again?

Take your burdens to the Lord — and leave them there.

③ COMMENTARY

Teacher preparation resource · Full text organized under outline headings

> **Proposition.** Paul, who had all the leverage he could want, approaches Philemon cautiously: he claims and commends him, wishes him grace and peace, thanks God for his love and faith, and rejoices that he has refreshed the saints — setting the stage, with great Christian tact, for the appeal to come.

Introduction

A cautious approach. Paul, who had all the leverage you could want in speaking to Philemon about a very delicate matter, didn't use the hammer. He had an iron fist and a velvet glove, you might say, in this section. So, starting here, we're looking at verses 1–7.

Before we get into the text, per se, let me remind us of some things that happened. Onesimus was a thieving, runaway slave. You can't get much worse than that. A thieving, runaway slave. He stole from his master, Philemon. He ran to the largest city he could find, so he could get lost — in Rome. Well, he didn't get lost from God, because he met Paul. And through Paul, he met the Lord. And the Lord is now going to send him back through Paul, back to his owner, Philemon.

Now, do you know what that's like? Can you imagine what it would be like to go back? Apparently — you don't hear anything about Onesimus saying, "I don't want to go." But I expect he didn't want to go. I had a teacher one time in college. He was teaching this book, and he was very much an actor. He said, "Here's the way Onesimus met Philemon." He became, say, Onesimus: "Master — letter, letter, letter from Paul! No, no — letter from Paul!" Because he knew what was coming. He knew what Philemon could do. He could kill him. And very often that happened.

Well, this letter is going to him. And guess who's going with it? Onesimus. And Onesimus is going with Tychicus, who's going to carry the Colossian Epistle — Colossae, which is where Philemon lived.

So, in the process, Paul's going to tell Philemon that he, Paul, would like to have Onesimus stay and serve in prison with him. Stay there with him. Be his helper. Then he says, "I won't do that unless I have your permission. And to make sure I have your permission, and you have the freedom to say yes or no, I'm sending him back to you. If you want him to come to me, you send him to me." And that's the way it's going to go.

So, this brings all sorts of questions to my mind. I expect yours as well. He is sending him back. Why? Why would he send him back to his master? He's a free man now. He's saved. He's a believer. Why does he have to go back to his master? Well, is Paul — or even the Bible, for that matter — in favor of slavery? Why doesn't he tell Philemon, even when he sends him back, to free him? He's not a slave anymore. He doesn't do that.

Paul does ask Philemon to take him back — not as a slave, but as a brother in Christ. That's a good step. He's not saying, "Don't make him a slave," but he's saying now, "Receive him as a brother." In so doing, I think, Paul gave not only some insight into the institution of

slavery in the Apostolic Age, but also his Christian response to it — how he and the Scriptures respond to this slavery. (The Bible Knowledge Commentary, Edwin Deibler.)

So with this background in mind, we'll begin to look at the epistle.

I. Greetings – vv. 1–2

A. Where They Were From – v. 1a–1b

1. Paul's Condition – v. 1a

"Paul, a prisoner of Christ Jesus,"

First of all, we have the greeting. Where did the greeting come from? Well, it comes from Paul. In Paul's condition, it is necessary to say: Where is he? What's he doing? Well, he's a prisoner. He is a prisoner of Jesus Christ. Notice: he is not a prisoner of Rome or of the Jews. He's sitting in prison in Rome, telling somebody in Asia Minor what to do. That's where he is.

2. Paul's Companions – v. 1b

"and Timothy our brother,"

And then Paul's companion, 1b — that's Timothy. So it's Paul, and Timothy our brother. He's including him in there, though Paul is the author. So that's where they're coming from. They're coming from Paul, and from Timothy as well.

B. Whom They Were For – vv. 1c–2

And then, to whom were they aimed, or whom were they for? They're for these people — for Philemon and others with him.

1. How He Claims Them

"To Philemon our beloved friend and fellow laborer, … Archippus our fellow soldier"

How he claims them. What do you mean, claims them? Well, he says "our" — our beloved friend Philemon, and our fellow laborer, and Archippus our fellow soldier. Our. They're his. That's a neat way to say it. If someone says to me, "Hey, this is my friend," I like that. Paul says "our."

Now, "our" — ἡμῶν — is plural. Now, what does he mean, our? Well, it could refer only to Paul, you know, like the royal pronoun. You've seen the royal monarch reading to the subjects and saying, "It is our privilege to have you as our subjects." It's just him, the king — or queen, if that's all you have. They say "our," see, but it's talking about one person. That happens. That's called the royal pronoun. It's also called the editorial pronoun. Sometimes editorially we say "our" or "we" instead of "I."

Well, I think more likely, though, it refers to Timothy. Paul and Timothy are writing this. And these people are not only our fellow laborers, but our companions — our fellow laborer, our fellow soldier. They're one of us. So there's a real connection between these two. And Paul is looking at them not as, "I am the big apostle and you are not." No, he's not saying that. He's saying, "We're fellows in this. We're together in this whole thing." And then they are

Paul's and Timothy's — plural — fellow laborer and fellow soldier, and he claims them as his very own.

There's nothing like expressed appreciation. You notice that? Don't look at me like that. You like it. When someone says, "You are a blessing to me" — you see? It feels good, doesn't it? And it's a proper thing to do, to express appreciation for people of fellow workers. And Paul is doing that. It's not just because he's trying to get something out of him. No, not that. What he's trying to do is say, "You are a friend of mine. You are part of the body of Christ. I love you." That's important. And we need to express that more and more. That's how he claims them.

2. How He Commends Them

And then he commends them.

a. Philemon the Saint

> *"To Philemon our beloved friend and fellow laborer,"*

Philemon, the beloved friend, a fellow laborer. He was also his friend. I like that. I got a call from a friend of mine. I'd talked with him for years — several years. And then he went on elsewhere and finally went up on the West Coast and got pretty high up there. He was a president of a seminary. And I called him one day. And when they got the call through to him, he answered the phone. He said, "Hey, my friend!" Hey, I'm a friend of this guy. Then he gave me his inside number: "Call me anytime you want." That's good. But — friend. He's a friend, he said. So, Philemon the saint is a friend of Paul.

b. Apphia the Sister

Apphia — Apphia the sister. Apphia is probably Philemon's wife. We don't know, but we assume. And Paul calls her not a sister. She is the sister. She's the sister.

> *"and to the church in your house:"*

We're going to see that there's a church in Philemon's house. Guess who has the problem with taking care of the house, getting the house ready, getting water? Apphia, his wife. Now — ladies, I'm talking to you; men, don't listen — do you ever have a time when your husband invites people over? "Oh, come over and see the game." Here they are. Who has to get the snacks ready? Not him. You know what I'm saying?

Apphia was the wife of the man who had the house, the church in his house. So he calls her the sister. And she was very special. Special to Paul. It doesn't say Philemon and her; it's Philemon and the sister. She's important too. Remember that. So — special to Paul, and to Philemon, and to the church, because the church is in their house.

The church apparently met in the house of Philemon. And Philemon's house must have been rather nice — large enough to have the church in there. And there were quite a few — not just three or four; it was a large group in the house of Philemon. And he was wealthy, then, from that. And then also from the fact that he owned slaves.

c. Archippus the Soldier

So, a third person is Archippus, the soldier. We shouldn't think of him as a Roman soldier. He's not talking like that. He's talking about a Christian soldier — a fellow soldier with Paul.

Paul had been there, remember. And here's one who, even if they hadn't served together, served in the same army. And here he is, a fellow soldier.

But he has something special to say about each of these people. And that's his greeting.

II. Grace and Peace – v. 3

He adds to that grace and peace, verse 3. Grace and peace.

A. Grace

Paul directs Philemon's thoughts toward three things — four things.

1. The Father of the Christian Family

"Grace to you and peace from God our Father"

Now, grace we hear mentioned as unmerited favor. That's good. It's not bad at all. But it seems to me that grace is more than that. It's not only unmerited. We merit something else. We deserve God's wrath. And God gives us His grace. So it's really favor — it's favor in spite of the demerit that we have with God. So, "while we were yet sinners," remember, "Christ died for us" — Romans 5:8. So it's grace in spite of our demerit.

2. The Focus of the Christian Faith — the Lord Jesus Christ

"and the Lord Jesus Christ."

And then the focus of the Christian faith: the Lord Jesus Christ. Three things.

a. The Lord – Power

"The Lord" emphasizes His power and His deity. And as deity, He is able to do, as Paul said in Ephesians, "exceedingly abundantly above all that we ask or think" [Ephesians 3:20]. That's the kind of Man we have. That's the kind of One we serve. And the One who has given us this grace — grace, because He also has that power. He is God.

b. Jesus – Person

Secondly, His person. Jesus, the person. Jesus is His human name. He's a Man. He is one of us. Not only one of us, but He's one with us. That's a big deal. He's not ashamed, Hebrews says, "not ashamed to call them brethren" [Hebrews 2:11]. That's what it is. He is one of us. Therefore, He could — and He did — die for us, and He died as us. That's the person we have.

c. Christ – Position

And then He's called Christ, and that is the position — the position that He has. We shouldn't confuse Messiahship with His deity. It's His messianic name. And His works, by the way, don't prove His deity. His works prove His Messiahship. This idea that, "Oh, look, Jesus walked on water; therefore He's God" — that doesn't follow. Who else walked on water? Peter. Then Peter is God, by that logic. So, they don't prove His deity. They prove His Messiahship.

How do I know that? Matthew 11, verses 2 through 6. John the Baptist was, remember, the one who was the forerunner of Jesus. He's the one who said, "He's coming. I'm here to tell you He is on His way." That's John the Baptist. And wouldn't you know where he is? He's in

prison. And he sent some of his disciples one day to Jesus and said, “Let me see now. I’m Your forerunner. I ought to be up there with You. I ought to be the one who is doing everything along with You. And I’m in prison. How come? Are You really the One, or are we looking for another?”

And Jesus didn’t say one way or the other. What He said was, “Go and tell John what you see.” What do you see? Well, you see the deaf hearing, the lame walking, the dead rising. That’s what you see. And so you just have to tell John that, and John will understand: “Oh yeah — You are the Messiah.” Not “You’re God,” but “You are the Messiah.” Anyway, that’s His position. He is the Christ.

B. Peace

So — grace, he says. “Grace to you and peace.”

1. Peace with God – Romans 5:1

Peace with God. Now, he’s not saying that he wants them to have peace with God. He’s writing to believers. Believers already have peace with God. Romans 5:1 says, “Therefore, having been justified by faith, we have peace with God through our Lord Jesus Christ.” So everyone who believes in Jesus is justified, and everyone who is justified has peace with God. It is a position which cannot change. So he’s not talking about that. That’s positional peace. But he’s praying that they have peace — grace and peace.

2. Peace of God – Philippians 4:6–7

Now, where do we get this peace? The peace of God. That’s important. Isn’t it important? Yes. Now, we have the peace of God: everything is in God’s control. Whatever problems we’re going through, we’re coming out on the other end — victorious. That’s the peace of God. In Philippians 4, beginning with verse 6, he says this:

> *“Be anxious for nothing, but in everything by prayer and supplication, with thanksgiving, let your requests be made known to God; and the peace of God, which surpasses all understanding, will guard your hearts and minds through Christ Jesus.”*

Wow. You mean this problem I have — I just talk to God about it and tell God what I need? That’s what He says. And when we do that — as a result of that — the peace of God, which surpasses all understanding, will guard, or garrison, your hearts and minds through Christ Jesus. That’s what he’s saying. He wants them to have not only the grace of God, but the peace of God — the peace of God which comes from laying all your burdens on Jesus.

Wow. Can we do that? Sure. It wouldn’t be in the Bible otherwise. But sometimes we take God’s place. If God’s going to take care of that, well, why am I taking it? Why am I worried about it? Let God take care of it. “Let your requests be made known to God.”

I heard about a preacher one time who preached on this passage, and to show it off — instead of being on the platform, he left to do the singing, leading singing. And when he got ready to preach, he came in the back door carrying a big bag, and it said on there, “BURDENS.” He laid the thing down right before the table, and he began to preach — preached from right there, when that wasn’t the thing to do. Anyway, he put the bag down and he preached. And he preached and he preached. Then he finished. And he dismissed, picked up his bag, put it on his shoulder, and carried it out. And there’s a little sticker here

and a little sticker over here. What's he doing? He took his burdens to the Lord. He's supposed to leave them there. They missed the whole point.

But that's what he says. Take your burdens to the Lord and let Him bear them. Don't pick them back up. After you go to Him in prayer and say, "Lord, here's what I need; here's what's happening," then don't go outside and say, "What am I going to do? I can't figure —" No. Peace — the peace of God. And Paul says, "I wish for you the peace of God."

III. Gratitude – vv. 4–6

You know: greetings, grace and peace, gratitude.

A. When Paul Prayed for Philemon – v. 4

"I thank my God, making mention of you always in my prayers,"

When Paul prayed for Philemon, verse 4, he says, "I thank my God, making mention of you always in my prayers." Paul had quite a prayer ministry, don't you think? "I pray for you. Every time I pray, I pray for you. I hold you in my prayers." He went on three missionary journeys, remember? Over in Galatia, in Asia Minor, over in Corinth. He was in three major places, had churches all around. And when he wrote to them, he said, "I pray for you." That's quite a ministry. He couldn't do that, apart from being in prison, I think — all kinds of time. This is one of the many advantages of his being in prison.

You know, one of my favorite prison students that we have now has time. He called me the other day and asked me a Greek question. And I told him what it was. He sent me an email saying, "Hey, that's good. Now I understand that." He wouldn't be doing Greek if he weren't in prison. But that's what he's doing. So Paul was doing the same thing. Paul was praying. He prayed for the people in Galatia and the people in Asia — had prayer all the time. And he says, "I make mention of you in my prayers always." So when he prayed, he included Philemon. He had time to do the real things that mattered. So when he prayed, he prayed for Philemon.

B. Why Paul Prayed for Philemon – vv. 5–6

Why did he pray for Philemon? 5a.

1. Philemon's Love for the Saints – v. 5a

"hearing of your love … toward all the saints,"

Philemon's love for the saints. "I pray for you, hearing of your love toward all the saints." Sometimes the little words are big, aren't they? "Hearing of your love to all the saints." Wow. Everyone — every saint is important. They know Jesus Christ. If they come to our church, they are important. All saints.

Paul knew these things because of the reports of Epaphras, and Onesimus, no doubt. But that's the ministry that Philemon had: he loved all the saints. "Hearing of your love. All the saints." "All the saints" would include the slaves, if they were believers — and Onesimus is now one of them. How about that? "I'm sending you back Onesimus. And he's a saint now. And you love all the saints."

You'll find Paul putting a dig here and a dig here and a dig all through this book. If you can, when you have time, read the whole thing several times. And you'll say, "Oh yeah, look at that." Paul's great. So — "all the saints." Got him. Did you hear that, Philemon? That's what he says. He prayed for him because of his love.

2. Philemon's Faith in the Lord Jesus – v. 5b

"faith which you have toward the Lord Jesus"

He prayed for him also because of his faith in the Lord Jesus Christ — "faith which you have toward the Lord Jesus." It's obvious, then, that the love he showed grew out of the faith he possessed. The love he showed grew out of the faith he possessed. It takes faith to see in someone who is not, maybe, the friendliest person — to see in that person — oh: because of what the Lord has done for me, I see what He can do for that person.

So, everyone who loves Him, John said, loves him who has been begotten by Him [1 John 5:1]. If you love the Lord, you love the Lord's people. What do you say? He couples faith in Christ and love for the saints all over his writings — in Ephesians, Colossians, Thessalonians. You see it in the first verses of all those epistles.

C. What Paul Prayed – v. 6

"that the sharing of your faith may become effective by the acknowledgment of every good thing which is in you in Christ Jesus."

And then not only when and why, but what Paul prayed, verse 6. He prayed — and I'm going to read the verse backward. It's all there backward. Good. "That the sharing of your faith may become effective by the acknowledgment of every good thing which is in you in Christ Jesus."

How does witnessing become effective? Well, witnessing becomes effective from that second part: that we understand everything that we have in Christ. Understand all that God has given me. We keep understanding that our faith in Christ — for everything that we need, for all the problems we have — our faith in Christ helps us with that. Wow. Then if that's the case, my faith that I have in Christ is good for those people too. Whether out there they need salvation — faith in Christ is going to be good for them. So I'd better tell them. Faith in Christ: if I know what happened for me, I know what can happen for them, whether they're out there or in here, wherever they are. My faith in Christ helps in my sharing of my faith.

If we don't have it, we can't share it. If we don't have that faith in Christ, we can't share it with other people. Apart from that, our witness has a hollow sound. It's like a bald barber selling hair restorer. "Sorry, no thank you. Until you get some hair on your head, then I'll take it." Until they see Christ in us, they're not going to see Christ anywhere else. That's what Paul prayed for him.

IV. Gladness – v. 7

And then his gladness. Verse 7: Paul is glad.

A. The Personal Experience of Philemon's Love

"For we have great joy and consolation in your love,"

His personal experience with Philemon's love: "For we have great joy and consolation in your love." Paul received great joy. You know what it is to have great joy? Of course you do. Great. One hymn says, "floods of joy" — "joy floods my soul." That can happen. And this is what Paul — the most important thing in Paul's life was making Christ known. And Paul had great joy from the love which Philemon expressed to other people, and to unbelievers. He also received consolation, or encouragement, by that. So Paul was thinking, "My ministry to him is not wasted."

I got a Christmas card from a student I hadn't heard from in about, probably, fifteen years. I was sitting at my desk one day. I was looking through the drawer for something, and I found a picture — a picture of this former student in 1998 with his family. The boy and girl were probably pre-teens. And that was with his wifeAnd the picture — and the mail came and there was a letter from Otto, a Christmas card from them. I thought, "Man, what a coincidence." And I had to write him and tell him what kind of a coincidence it was that I'd heard from him. And I went online, found him — pastor of a Baptist church. A great ministry, Southern Baptist. And I think that's great. And I'm into this too. I say, "Here he is." My ministry to him was not wasted. He's there serving the Lord.

And Paul looks at Philemon and says, "Man, that guy — he was nothing until he found Christ. And now look what he's doing." And that is such a thrill to me.

B. The Practical Expression of Philemon's Love

"because the hearts of the saints have been refreshed by you, brother."

And then he talks about the practical expression of Philemon's love: "because the hearts of the saints have been refreshed by you, brother." Now, that word "heart" is not the thing that pumps blood. The word is not καρδία, but σπλάγχνα, which refers to the inner parts of the body. It's the innermost being — splanchna. It's the emotions. It is a deep emotional term. And so he says the innermost being, the emotions, have been refreshed.

Now, what does that word "refresh" mean? Well, Jesus used it in Matthew 11:28. He said, "Come to Me, all you who labor and are heavy laden, and I will give you rest." It's the word — literally, "I will refresh you." You're working hard. You've labored for the Lord. The people around Philemon got that kind of response. They were refreshed by what Philemon had done. So in this case, then, the saints had been brought to Jesus by one of His servants through a witness of the Word, and they were refreshed by that experience.

And then he adds one thing. I like this. He says they are refreshed "by you, brother." Can you feel that? You say, "Oh — my name is Brother. He calls me brother." And that's where he ends. It may have touched his heart. I believe it did. It certainly set the stage for the next thing, where he has the comprehensive appeal (Philemon 8–19). "Now I'm ready. Okay, brother." And then he jumps into verse 8 and following.

Conclusion

I don't know about you, but I think that I'd love to hear that somebody as big as Paul, the greatest evangelist ever — that he would stop to talk to somebody — there's a little guy over there in Asia Minor — and not tell him what to do. He could have. "Am I not an apostle?" he

said to the Corinthians [1 Corinthians 9:1]. Of course he is. But instead of that, he said, “I’m going to lay the cards on the table, so to speak. And I’m going to tell him what I’d like to have him do. And I’m going to take the velvet glove on the iron fist and let him know what I want him to do. But then let the Lord work in his heart to do it.”

The great Christian tact. We need it. We must have it for the ministry of the Lord.

Lord, thank You.

④ SELF-STUDY GUIDE

For use during the group meeting · Focused on the commentary text

Greek Word Study

Verse	Greek Word / English	Strong's # / Translit. / Form	Definition & Significance
v.1	**δέσμιος** *prisoner*	G1198 *desmios* N-Nom. Sg. Masc.	STR: one bound, a captive. ATR: Paul names his chains as belonging to Christ, not to Rome. Significance: Paul writes as "a prisoner of Christ Jesus" — not of Rome or of the Jews.
v.1	**συνεργῷ** *fellow laborer*	G4904 *synergos* Adj.-Dat. Sg. Masc.	STR: a co-worker, helper. VINE: used by Paul of those who share his gospel labor. Significance: with "our," Paul claims Philemon as one of his own — "we're fellows in this."
v.1	**ἀγαπητῷ** *beloved*	G27 *agapētos* Adj.-Dat. Sg. Masc.	STR: beloved, dear. Significance: Paul leads with love and appreciation; there is nothing like expressed appreciation of fellow workers.
v.2	**Ἀπφίᾳ** *Apphia*	G682 *Apphia* N-Dat. Sg. Fem. (proper name)	Significance: probably Philemon's wife. NKJV (Majority/TR) reads "the beloved (ἀγαπητῇ) Apphia"; the critical text reads "the sister" (τῇ ἀδελφῇ), the reading the sermon draws on.
v.2	**συστρατιώτῃ** *fellow soldier*	G4961 *systratiōtēs* N-Dat. Sg. Masc.	STR: a fellow soldier. VINE: used figuratively of a fellow worker in Christian service (also Phil. 2:25). Significance: a Christian soldier, not a Roman one — they served in the same army.
v.2	**ἐκκλησίᾳ** *church*	G1577 *ekklēsia* N-Dat. Sg. Fem.	STR: a called-out assembly. Significance: "the church in your house" — the congregation met in Philemon's home, suggesting a large house and a man of means.
v.3	**χάρις** *grace*	G5485 *charis* N-Nom. Sg. Fem.	THAY: favor, kindness granted to one who has not deserved it. Significance: not only unmerited favor but favor in spite of demerit (Rom. 5:8).
v.3	**εἰρήνη** *peace*	G1515 *eirēnē* N-Nom. Sg. Fem.	LXX: renders shalom — wholeness and well-being. Significance: believers already have peace with God (Rom. 5:1); Paul wishes them the peace of God (Phil. 4:6–7).
v.4	**μνείαν** *mention*	G3417 *mneia* N-Acc. Sg. Fem.	STR: remembrance, mention. Significance: "making mention of you always" — Paul's prison prayer ministry had time for the things that mattered.
v.5	**ἀγάπην** *love*	G26 *agapē* N-Acc. Sg. Fem.	VINE: love that seeks the good of its object. Significance: love "toward all the saints" — and Onesimus is one of them now.
v.5	**πίστιν** *faith*	G4102 *pistis* N-Acc. Sg. Fem.	STR: belief, trust. Significance: Philemon's love grew out of the faith he possessed; Paul couples the two in the opening of Ephesians, Colossians, and Thessalonians.
v.6	**κοινωνία**	G2842	THAY: fellowship, participation, communication.

Verse	Greek Word / English	Strong's # / Translit. / Form	Definition & Significance
	sharing	*koinōnia* N-Nom. Sg. Fem.	Significance: “the sharing of your faith” — the sermon reads it as witnessing.
v.6	**ἐπιγνώσει** *acknowledgment*	G1922 *epignōsis* N-Dat. Sg. Fem.	MRV: full, precise knowledge. Significance: witnessing becomes effective as we understand everything we have in Christ; apart from that, our witness has a hollow sound.
v.7	**σπλάγχνα** *hearts*	G4698 *splanchna* N-Nom. Pl. Neut.	STR: the inward parts; figuratively, the affections. Significance: not καρδία (the heart) but the innermost being — the emotions. A deep emotional term.
v.7	**ἀναπέπαυται** *have been refreshed*	G373 *anapauō* Perf. Pass. Ind. 3rd Sg.	STR: to cause to rest, refresh. Significance: the same word Jesus used in Matt. 11:28 — “I will give you rest,” literally “I will refresh you.” Perfect tense: refreshment with lasting effect.

Cases: Nom. · Gen. · Dat. · Acc. · Voc. | Number: Sg. · Pl. | Gender: Masc. · Fem. · Neut. | Verb Mood: Ind. · Imp. · Subj. · Opt. · Inf. · Ptc. | Tense: Pres. · Imperf. · Fut. · Aor. · Perf. · Plpf. | Voice: Act. · Mid. · Pass. | Person: 1st/2nd/3rd Sg./Pl.

Sources: STR = Strong’s · THAY = Thayer’s · ATR = A.T. Robertson, Word Pictures · VINE = Vine’s · MRV = Vincent’s Word Studies · LXX = Septuagint usage. Parsing: Blue Letter Bible.

Study Questions

Part 1 — From the Commentary

Question	Answer
Why was Onesimus afraid to go back?	He was a thieving, runaway slave, and Philemon could punish him — even kill him; very often that happened.
Whom does the “our” in v. 1 most likely include?	Timothy. It could be a royal or editorial pronoun, but more likely Paul and Timothy are claiming Philemon and Archippus as their own.
How does the commentary define grace?	Not only unmerited favor but favor in spite of demerit — “while we were yet sinners, Christ died for us.”
What do Jesus’ works prove, according to the commentary?	His Messiahship, not His deity (Matt. 11:2–6). Peter walked on water too.
What is the difference between peace with God and the peace of God?	Peace with God is the positional peace of every justified believer (Rom. 5:1); the peace of God guards the heart when we bring our requests to Him (Phil. 4:6–7).
What makes the sharing of our faith effective (v. 6)?	Understanding every good thing we have in Christ. If we don’t have it, we can’t share it.

Part 2 — Study Questions

1. Paul had the authority to command Philemon. Why does he begin with greetings, grace, gratitude, and gladness instead?

> *Leader note: He chose the velvet glove over the iron fist. He sets the stage with love and appreciation so that Philemon is free to respond from the heart — “the great Christian tact.”*

2. What does it mean that Paul claims Philemon and Archippus as "our" fellow laborer and fellow soldier?

> *Leader note: Paul is not saying, "I am the big apostle and you are not." He is saying, "We're fellows in this." There is nothing like expressed appreciation of fellow workers.*

3. Why does the commentary say Jesus' works prove His Messiahship rather than His deity?

> *Leader note: Because others also did mighty works — Peter walked on water. When John the Baptist asked, Jesus pointed to His works so that John would know He is the Messiah (Matt. 11:2–6). His deity is emphasized in the title "Lord."*

4. What does the preacher's "burdens" bag illustrate about the peace of God?

> *Leader note: The preacher took his bag of burdens to the front and then carried it out again. We are to take our burdens to the Lord and leave them there; the peace of God guards our hearts when we do (Phil. 4:6–7).*

5. Where is the "dig" in v. 5, and how does it prepare for Paul's request?

> *Leader note: "Your love … toward all the saints." Onesimus is a saint now, so Philemon's love for all the saints must include him.*

Part 3 — Passage Summary

Verse(s)	Theme	Key Truth
vv. 1–2	Greetings	Paul writes as Christ's prisoner, with Timothy, and claims and commends Philemon, Apphia, Archippus, and the church in the house.
v. 3	Grace and Peace	Grace from the Father and from the Lord (power), Jesus (person), Christ (position); not peace with God, which believers have, but the peace of God.
vv. 4–6	Gratitude	Paul always prays for Philemon because of his love for all the saints and his faith in the Lord Jesus, and prays that his sharing of the faith would be effective.
v. 7	Gladness	Philemon's love brought Paul joy and consolation, and refreshed the hearts of the saints — "by you, brother."

⑤ APPLICATION

Closes the study · Personal & corporate

Application 1 — Say It Out Loud

Philemon 1–2

Drawn from Commentary I.B (How He Claims Them) and Devotional ②.

Paul calls Philemon “our beloved friend and fellow laborer” and Archippus “our fellow soldier.” He claims them as his very own before he asks them for anything. There is nothing like expressed appreciation. It feels good to hear “you are a blessing to me,” and it is a proper thing to say.

Reflection: Who has labored beside you in the Lord’s work and never heard you say thank you?

Practical Step: This week tell one fellow worker, in person or in writing, “You are a blessing to me” — and mean it without asking for anything.

Application 2 — Leave the Bag at the Front

Philippians 4:6–7

Drawn from Commentary II.B (Peace of God) and Greek Word Study (εἰρήνη).

Believers already have peace with God. What Paul wishes for Philemon is the peace of God, which comes from laying all our burdens on Jesus. The preacher in the story carried his bag of burdens to the front and then carried it out again. We are to take our burdens to the Lord and leave them there.

Reflection: What burden have you prayed about and then picked back up?

Practical Step: Write down one worry, pray it through with thanksgiving, and when it returns, say, “I already gave that to the Lord.”

Application 3 — Love All the Saints

Philemon 5

Drawn from Commentary III.B (Why Paul Prayed) and Study Question 5.

Paul praises Philemon’s love “toward all the saints” — and Onesimus is a saint now. Love that grows out of faith sees in a hard-to-love person what the Lord can do for him. If you love the Lord, you love the Lord’s people.

Reflection: Is there a believer you have quietly left out of “all the saints”?

Practical Step: Pray by name for one believer you find hard to love, and take one concrete step of kindness toward him or her.

Application 4 — Know What You Have Before You Share It

Philemon 6

Drawn from Commentary III.C (What Paul Prayed) and Greek Word Study (ἐπίγνωσις).

Our witness becomes effective as we understand every good thing that is ours in Christ. If we don’t have it, we can’t share it — like a bald barber selling hair restorer. Until people see Christ in us, they are not going to see Christ anywhere else.

Reflection: Could you tell someone this week what faith in Christ has done for you?

Practical Step: List three good things you have in Christ, and share one of them with someone who needs it.

End of Study · Philemon 1–7